from the Sikhs. Vitkevitch claimed he was ‘authorized to say to Maharajah Ranjit Singh that if that chieftain did not act in a friendly manner to the Afghans, Russia will send money easily . . . to Kabul to raise troops to fight the Sikhs for the recovery of his country . . .’ He added that ‘fifty thousand men of Russian regiments were in readiness to land at Astarabad . . . who would then march towards the Punjab; that such movements would rouse all the discontented chiefs of India to rebel; and that the English, who are not soldiers, but merely mercantile adventurers, would not dare to assist Ranjit Singh, knowing that the Afghans are succoured by the warlike nation of Russia’.[101]

Vitkevitch was on the verge of winning the contest for Kabul. On 23 March, Dost Mohammad went to see Burnes for the last time. He had lost hope, he told his friend. ‘I wish no countenance but that of the English,’ said the Amir, ‘but you refuse all pledges and promises, and mean to do nothing for me.’[102] Meanwhile, certainty was growing that the Persians and their Russian allies would soon take Herat and march on into Afghanistan; in response the ethnically Persian Qizilbash Shias of Kabul processed triumphantly through the Kabul streets with a new confidence. ‘An event’, wrote Burnes, ‘unknown to the eldest inhabitants, and which a short time since would have caused a religious tumult.’[103]

Finally, a month later, on 21 April, Dost Mohammad summoned Vitkevitch and had him escorted with a troop of his own cavalry through the streets of Kabul. He received him in the Bala Hisar with full honours. In formal durbar, while Burnes sat alone in his rooms on the other side of the palace complex, Vitkevitch told the Amir that Russia did not recognise the Sikh conquests in Afghan territory and that in the eyes of Russia Peshawar, Multan and Kashmir all still belonged de jure to Afghanistan. He said Russia wished to see a strong and united Afghanistan which Russia would protect diplomatically as an unbreakable barrier against British expansion into Central Asia. He admitted that Russia was too far away to despatch troops at short notice, but promised to give Dost Mohammad money to fight Ranjit Singh, and told him, according to Mohan Lal, much that was ‘anything but complimentary about the British’. He also promised that Russia would protect Afghan traders in Russia. In response, Dost Mohammad offered to send his son, Mohammad Azam Khan, to meet Count Simonitch at the Persian camp outside Herat and to confirm in person the Amir’s intentions of opening permanent friendly relations with Russia.